

Gazans, Israelis rejoice over truce

Deal would free 1,950 Palestinians and 48 Hamas hostages. U.S. will send 200 troops.

By NABIH BULOS

TEL AVIV — After two years of devastating war that killed tens of thousands of people, left millions displaced and pulverized much of Gaza into an apocalyptic moonscape, Israelis and Palestinians celebrated a long-awaited deal to end the conflict, return Israeli hostages and release Palestinians held in prison.

After a lengthy meeting that stretched from Thursday evening into early Friday morning, the Israeli Cabinet approved what it called an “outline” of the deal.

But even before the Cabinet acted, news of the deal sparked celebrations throughout Israel. The pact was greeted with relief and joy in Gaza, where the militant group Hamas said the agreement would end the war and lead to Israel’s full withdrawal from the Palestinian enclave and to the entry of desperately needed aid.

The deal caps months of tortuous ceasefire negotiations and delivers a denouement to a generation-defining fight in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

President Trump on Thursday hailed the agreement as a “momentous breakthrough.” The night before, he posted on his social media platform that the deal would involve the hostage-detainee swap along with the Israeli military’s withdrawal from parts of Gaza — “the first steps towards a Strong, durable, and Everlasting Peace,” according to Trump.

“BLESSED ARE THE PEACEMAKERS,” he wrote.

The U.S. will send 200 troops to Israel to help monitor the ceasefire, the Associated Press reported.

In Gaza, where Israel’s no-holds-barred assault upended lives, erased entire families and brought famine to the enclave, residents expressed cautious hope.

“I never thought I’d see this day. We’ve been wanting it to come for months now, and then suddenly it happened so fast,” said Ali al-Azab, 34, from the central city of Deir al Balah.

“We’ve been living in fear for so long, waiting for the next bomb to come, to lose another friend. But I also know the war isn’t over yet.”

[See Ceasefire, A4]

Risks for Hamas and Netanyahu

Truce creates political uncertainty for militant group’s leaders and Israeli premier. **WORLD, A4**



MENACHEM KAHANA AFP/Getty Images



MOIZ SALHI Anadolu

CHRISTIAN pilgrims and other foreigners in Jerusalem, top, march through a market in support of the ceasefire deal. In Deir al Balah, Palestinians at the Nu-seirat camp gather to celebrate. “I never thought I’d see this day,” one Gazan said.

STATE TEST SCORES IMPROVE AMID PANDEMIC SETBACKS

California student test scores remain lower than before the pandemic, but are trending upward, with the Compton and L.A. school districts among those with especially strong growth and results that have surpassed pre-pandemic levels.

Against this backdrop of progress, Gov. Gavin Newsom on Thursday signed legislation mandating that phonics must be emphasized when teaching the state’s youngest students how to read, a sweeping effort to elevate lagging skills and raise student achievement.

On the statewide tests, which were taken in the spring, 48.8% of students scored as “proficient” or “advanced” in English Language Arts, a gain of 1.8 percentage points from the spring of 2024,

LAUSD and Compton Unified schools are among the high fliers for progress

By Howard Blume and Jenny Gold

which built on smaller gains from the previous year. Still, the percentage scoring as advanced or proficient was 2.1 percentage points lower than in 2018-19, the last full year before the COVID-19 pandemic.

The trend was similar for math, with fewer students advanced or proficient overall.

In math, 37.3% of tested students scored as proficient or advanced, again an increase of 1.8 percentage points from 2024. And 2024 was 0.9% percentage point better than 2023. However, the percentage of proficient students was lower than pre-pandemic, by 2.4 percentage points.

A statement from the California De-

[See Scores, A14]

Years after death, he faced deportation

Homeland Security’s push is dragging in the dead and unnerving immigrant families.

By Rachel Uranga

Jose Mario Rodriguez Grimaldi was weak and unable to eat in his final days after contracting COVID. He died peacefully in his daughter’s Winnetka home at age 88.

Three years after his death, he was facing deportation proceedings.



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

JOSE MARIO Rodriguez Grimaldi died in 2022 at 88 but received two letters for deportation this year.

LAFD admits Jan. 7 failures and vows fixes

City releases report on Palisades fire, says staffing will rise during high-risk weather.

By ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN

Los Angeles firefighters will remain on duty for an additional shift during red flag weather warnings in a mandatory protocol instituted after top fire officials failed to pre-deploy engines to Pacific Palisades in advance of the devastating Jan. 7 fire.

Mayor Karen Bass’ announcement Wednesday came after the Los Angeles Fire Department released a long-awaited after-action report finding that firefighters were hampered by an ineffective process for recalling them back to work, as well as poor communication, inexperienced leadership and a lack of resources.

The release of the 70-page report, and Bass’ recitation of changes the department has made in line with the report, came on the heels of federal prosecutors arresting and charging a 29-year-old Uber driver with intentionally setting a blaze on Jan. 1 that later grew into the

[See Report, A8]

Key takeaways from the report

- Nine months after fire ravaged Pacific Palisades, the LAFD released its after-action assessment of the firefight. Among the findings:
 - Too few firefighters were on duty when the blaze erupted, and the process for calling them back to work was ineffective.
 - Resources were lacking as the department failed to pre-deploy additional engines.
 - Several top department officials “had limited or no experience” in managing a fire of that magnitude.
 - There was a delay in communicating evacuation orders, and a lack of structured traffic control led to blocked routes.
- Source: Los Angeles Fire Department

Is L.A. liable for Palisades fire costs?

By Jenny Jarvie

When federal prosecutors arrested a man Wednesday on suspicion of setting a small fire that reignited days later into the deadly Palisades blaze, they suggested the arrest largely settled the matter of blame.

“A single person’s recklessness caused one of the worst fires Los Angeles has ever seen,” Bill Essayli, acting United States attorney for Central California, said as he announced the arrest of Jonathan Rinderknecht, a 29-year-old Uber driver.

But the new details they offered about the cause of the fire only added to residents’ anger and dismay about how city officials handled the disaster, which killed 12 people and destroyed thousands of homes across Pacific Palisades and Malibu. It also renewed calls for City Hall to be held accountable.

Until this week, the focus of Palisades residents has been on a reservoir that was supposed to be a key source of water for the neighborhood being dry and other issues related to the fire response. But federal investigators concluded Wednesday that L.A. firefighters thought they had put out the small fire Rinderknecht allegedly set Jan. 1 only for it to smolder and burn underground and then rekindle in heavy winds Jan. 7.

This latest revelation is fueling debate over whether the city of L.A. or the state can be found civilly liable for its role in the fire.

[See Liability, A8]

ANALYSIS

Praise, peril for Trump peace plan

By Michael Wilner

WASHINGTON — At a moment when hope for peace seemed lost, senior U.S. officials, led by then-Secretary of State Hillary Clinton, brokered a ceasefire between Israel and Hamas in 2012 that would be touted for years as a historic diplomatic achievement. She would later campaign on her strategic prowess for the presidency against Donald Trump.

In 2014, a similar ceasefire was brokered between the two parties during yet another war by Clinton’s successor, John Kerry, also seen at the time as a diplomatic coup. But in the first 72 hours of that ceasefire, without clarity on the precise lines of an Israeli withdrawal from Gaza, Hamas operatives ambushed an Israel Defense Forces patrol decommissioning a tunnel, throwing peace in doubt. The remains of the Israeli soldier caught in that raid have been held by Hamas ever since.

History shows that Trump’s achievement this week, brokering a new truce between Israel and Hamas

after their most devastating war yet, is filled with opportunity and peril for the president.

A lasting ceasefire could cement him a legacy as a peacemaker, long sought by Trump, who has harnessed President Nixon’s madman theory of diplomacy to coerce several other warring parties into ceasefires and settlements. But the record of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict shows that consistent interest and engagement by the president may be necessary to ensure any peace can hold.

[See Analysis, A7]

James indicted on fraud charge

New York’s attorney general is the latest case against a perceived enemy of President Trump. **NATION, A6**

Kimmel defends Kirk comments

Late-night host says foes “maliciously mischaracterized” remarks about slain conservative activist. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather
Turning sunny.
L.A. Basin: 83/63. **B6**



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LOOKING TO ADVANCE

Shohei Ohtani heads to first base in Game 4 of the NLDS. For full series coverage, visit latimes.com/dodgers or latimes.com/enewspaper.